

is the *ThinkVantage* button that allows quick access to help and support. The USB ports are laid out vertically which is actually pretty clever design since two ports can be placed very close to each other thereby saving space. The RJ11 and RJ45 connects are also placed together on one side; convenient. The WLAN switch is on the front this time; so it scores in terms of placement ergonomics over its costlier sibling.

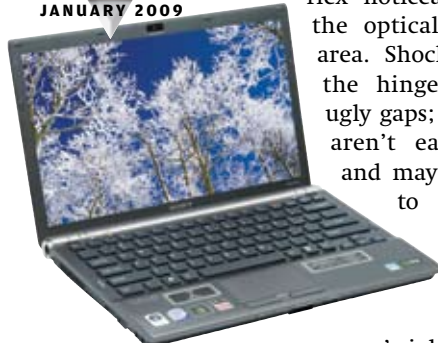
Powered by the new P8400 which is part of the new Montevina platform the T400 is snappy; but comes with just 1 GB of RAM (DDR3). We figure Vista users should look for at least 2 GB of memory and cannot figure out why Lenovo chose to supply just 1 GB; unless it was to keep the price down. The hard drive is a regular 5400 rpm, 160 GB offering. The T400 also makes do without any sort of discrete graphics offering favouring Intel's trusty old GMA 4500. Priced at Rs. 68,000, the T400 is very competent for the build, specifications, functionality and features it offers. Anyone who is used to the build of Lenovo's ThinkPad's will not be disappointed. We wish for a GeForce 9300M-class graphics solution and an HDMI port; which would make this notebook more of an all-rounder but as it is the hardware on offer is good enough for its target audience.

Sony Vaio VGN-Z13GN

Ultra portable performer

Sony's Z series are aimed at the stylish businessman looking for a no compromise machine that serves a dual purpose – rock solid portability and strong multimedia capabilities. The Vaio VGN-Z13GN is a very compact notebook that has an understated black and steel-grey finish that attracts at first sight. The lid is one of the slimmest we've ever

seen and this notebook is definitely the slimmest in this comparison. The lid has a nice positive snap shut action when it's about an inch from being fully closed. The outer shell is made partly of carbon fiber which gives the Vaio Z the binary benefits of tremendous robustness and low overall weight. We felt that as good as that may sound, this Vaio should have been built even better and there was some



Sony Vaio VGN-Z13GN

flex noticeable around the optical drive tray area. Shockingly even the hinge has some ugly gaps; while these aren't easy to spot and may not matter to most people being retentive is part of a reviewers' job. The rear

plastics are good quality but not as good as the materials we've seen on the Vaio TZ series. The screen is a very high resolution 1600 x 900 pixels and at a size of 13.3-inches it's not the ideal proportions for someone looking to work with text. However, colours and contrast on the display are good, but this is a TN panel and you will have issues with wider viewing angles.

The keypad is typically Sony, with a kind of soft, mushy feedback. The layout is very good though, although the keys feel a little smaller than some other Vaio's they are also a little higher than normal meaning that key travel is more. The gap between the keys on this keypad seems to be slightly more than the gaps on the segregated keypad that Apple uses. Whether or not this is good, is for you to decide but our overall opinion is positive and nobody had any ergonomic issues while using it and the all important control key is at the

left corner, just as it should be – Lenovo should take a leaf out of Sony's book here. The trackpad is better than the Lenovo series in terms of accuracy and the choice of coating is also good as it aids finger grip. The WiFi indicator light is on the front bezel and not at all visible unless you eye is at the same angle which rarely happens; the switch is located below it and is easy to operate.

The VGN-Z13GN also features the famous switch to select between stamina and speed mode. This is basically a hardware level switch between the integrated graphics solution (Intel) to the NVIDIA GeForce 9300M GS. This allows you to either get more graphics horsepower or conserve battery life depending on your usage patterns at the moment.

In terms of processing power the Vaio is fully loaded – with 4 GB of DDR3 memory and an Intel P9500 CPU running at 2.5 GHz. A 320 GB hard drive offers more than enough storage for all but the most demanding of download junkies. When viewing the specifications of this notebook we feel more strongly than ever that this Vaio is designed to perform dual roles. It can be a faithful corporate aid and a fun-time plaything as well; and it's equally adroit at both tasks, and yes; it's also got an HDMI port. It was also the smallest and lightest notebook (1.48 kg) in test making it something of a specialty since it's also the most powerful notebook in test in terms of processing power and performance. At Rs. 124,900 we wish it were just a little sturdier; but given its other multifaceted talents we have very little to nitpick about. If you can afford to spend this much cash; this is the only notebook you need consider. ■

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